

Study Questions: Perception

1. Distinguish between direct realism, representationalism, and inferentialism as accounts of perception. Which does Active Inference align with?
2. What did Helmholtz mean by "unconscious inference," and how does this anticipate the predictive processing framework?
3. Explain the concept of prediction error. What is its philosophical significance for understanding perceptual experience?
4. How does Merleau-Ponty's account of tool transparency relate to the concept of prediction error in Active Inference?
5. What is Hoffman's user-interface theory of perception? How does it challenge naive realism?
6. In what ways does Active Inference agree with and differ from Hoffman's user-interface theory?
7. How does the pragmatist epistemology of James and Dewey relate to the Active Inference view that generative models need not "mirror" reality?
8. If perception is inference, what does this imply about the distinction between "seeing" and "believing"?
9. How does Active Inference explain hallucinations? Is this a strength or weakness of the framework?
10. What is the role of precision in Active Inference's account of perception? How does it relate to attention?
11. Can an agent with a false generative model still perceive successfully? What is the philosophical implication?
12. How does Gibson's ecological psychology challenge the inferentialist account? Can the two be reconciled?
13. What is the "dark room problem," and what does it reveal about the Active Inference account of perception?
14. How does perceptual learning (expertise) illustrate the Active Inference framework?
15. Compare the Kantian notion that the mind structures experience with the Active Inference claim that generative models shape perception.

16. If we only ever access our own predictions (updated by prediction error), are we trapped in a "veil of predictions"? How does this compare to the classical veil of ideas?
17. What is the phenomenological difference between perceiving something and imagining it? How does Active Inference account for this difference?
18. How does the concept of "active perception" (saccades, haptic exploration) relate to the Active Inference framework?
19. Evaluate the claim: "Perception is controlled hallucination." Is this a helpful or misleading metaphor?
20. How would a phenomenologist (e.g., Husserl) respond to the claim that perception is Bayesian inference?